

Spicing Up CLI Apps with GUI

In this age of innumerable GUI-driven utilities on our GNU/Linux systems, we are bound to come across several command-line programs with boring and user-unfriendly text console-based operations. Wouldn't it be fun if we could add some GUI features to command-line applications without any tedious GUI programming effort?

Dressing up a command-line program with some form of a graphical skin is possible with very little effort, using utilities like Dialog and Xdialog. We can use these for most programming languages like C, C++, Python, Ruby, Perl, Bash, etc, to create GUI-based applications, without any GUI programming effort at all.

In this article, we will explore how to turn our boring command-line applications into some spicier and more user friendly forms with a GUI. I used the Ubuntu 9.10 64-bit desktop edition and Puppy Linux 4.2.1 to test the code

and to generate the screenshots presented in this article.

Dialog and Xdialog

Dialog is a curses/curses libraries-based program that creates interactive text-mode graphical controls, or widgets, on text consoles. It can easily be plugged into existing command-line applications without the need for any serious programming efforts to turn text-based applications into interactive GUI-based utilities. The newer versions of Dialog are based on